theory of violent invasion has since been disproved by more solid archaeological evidence, which points to the arrival of a predominantly pastoralist people by degrees and over an extended period. But these were a people habituated by centuries of nomadic living to an austere way of life. They built no temples to their gods, only fire-altars, fire-pits and sacrificial posts – and even here there is astonishingly little archaeological evidence. We know that *yajna*, or animal sacrifice, played a hugely important role in the Arya's religious rites, and that complex *vedi*s, or fire-altars, had to be constructed employing various patterns of bricks depending on the sacrifice involved, and that each time a sacrifice was repeated the fire-altar had to be enlarged. Yet, for all these requirements, no such fire-altars have ever been found. It is quite possible that they were destroyed after use, because this was a culture entirely unconcerned with the material or permanent settlement – initially, at least.

But above all, the Arya saw themselves as a people invested in knowledge, encapsulated in a single word: *veda*. To my mind, no one has put it better than the Italian publisher and philosopher Roberto Calasso as to what made the Arya so special. 'It was the civilization in which the invisible prevailed over the visible,' he has written.

> There is no point looking for help from historical events, since there is no trace of them. Only texts remain: the *Veda*, the Knowledge, consisting of hymns, invocations, incantations in verse, of ritual formulas and prescriptions in prose … Their minds teemed with images. Perhaps this was also why they had no interest in fashioning and sculpting figures of the gods. As if, already surrounded by them, they felt no need to add others … There are very few tangible remains of the Vedic period – no buildings survive, no ruins or traces of buildings. At most, a few meagre fragments on show in